Does Everybody Have Access to Technology?

STEP 1 RAISING AWARENESS

1A **How does technology help you in your daily life? On a sticky note, write your name and the technology that is important for you. Write a sentence to explain what you use it for. Put your note on your classroom wall.**

B **Read your classmates' notes and answer the question.**

How does technology make our lives easier?

C **Read the definition of 'digital divide' and underline the key words.**

> **digital divide** the differences of opportunity that exist between people who can regularly and easily use digital technology (e.g. smartphones, tablets, the internet), and people who cannot do this

D **Work in pairs. Compare your key words from Ex 1C. Then make a list of people in our society who have limited access to technology.**

STEP 2 GOING AHEAD

2A **Read the article and look at your answers to Ex 1D. Can you add any other categories to your list?**

B **Match the words in bold in the article with their meanings (1–4).**

1 when both men and women are treated in the same way and have the same opportunities

2 the process of becoming stronger, especially in controlling one's own life

3 a machine or tool

4 designing a process such as learning, solving a problem or being a customer so that it is like a game



Access to technology

1 **Balqees Shahin**, 23, from Jordan, is a member of the Arabic HeForShe movement which, in partnership with other NGOs, set up a **gamification** platform on **gender equality** and women's **empowerment**. The platform was developed entirely in Jordan by a group of young people and is the first of its kind in that it gives a virtual space where young women can connect and combine their skills and knowledge to support social causes. In a society where there is gender inequality in the physical world, there is often the same inequality in the digital world. Access to technology can change the lives of young women and their communities.

2 **Sharifah Sharizah** lives in the north of Malaysia, in an area with no internet coverage. Every day, she has to get up early and walk 5 km with her children to the nearest place that has an internet connection. That is the only way for her children to attend online classes. These classes are the only way to access education when you live in isolated places. Sometimes, Sharifah can use a car, but the conditions for driving can be too dangerous. Another problem that many families have is the lack of devices for their children. Often, there is only one mobile phone and the children have to share the same **device**.

3 **Jeremy Harper**, 24, from Connecticut, USA, collaborates as a researcher to a special programme led by a non-profit organisation which provides old people with low-cost internet, devices and digital training. When he meets the participants in the programme, who are all between 65 and 98, they like sharing their views on their experiences with technology with him. One of them told him that he felt he was standing outside a locked door to a building he needed to get into. Another told him she feels as if she were no longer part of this society, and that there were things she couldn't participate in without the internet. Grey digital divide is a major challenge for older people. It can mean that they don't benefit from the digital revolution. Technology can be an important way to reduce loneliness and isolation among older people. Jeremy Harper believes it is important to ensure they have the skills they need to access the digital world. He feels there is a need for greater investment in designing devices specifically for older adults.

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C **Read the article again. Are the statements true (T), false (F) or not given (NG)?**

1 The HeForShe movement has been promoting initiatives to fight the gender digital divide. .....

2 According to Balqees Shahin, women tend to use the internet differently from men. .....

3 Sharifah's story shows how the digital divide can be related to low levels of infrastructure and network quality. .....

4 According to Jeremy Harper, old people are more likely to share false information online. .....

5 Grey digital divide is the gap between men's and women's ability to access and use the internet and digital technologies. .....

D **Match each story in the article (1–3) with at least one of the factors (a–e) causing the digital divide.**

a low literacy and digital skill levels

b geographical restrictions

c limited or no access to technology

d gender or age

e affordability

Language for citizenship

3 **Match the sentence halves to complete the ideas to reduce the digital divide.**

1 As affordability is a chief barrier, subsidies should be given

2 Teachers and students need to be trained to

3 The government should provide technology to areas that

4 According to the UN, governments should actively help to

5 As cultural issues can be hindrances to digital progress, campaigns to

a reduce the prices of technological devices, internet services and electricity.

b make everyone aware of the benefits of digital literacies should be promoted at all levels.

c to low-income people to encourage them to buy the digital tools they need.

d private companies do not consider profitable enough to include in their networks.

e effectively use the internet and digital tools.

CRITICAL THINKING

The Italian Constitution

4A **Work in pairs. Read Article 3 of the Italian Constitution and answer the question.**

What is the possible impact of the digital divide on our society?

Tutti i cittadini hanno pari dignità sociale e sono eguali davanti alla legge, senza distinzione di sesso, di razza, di lingua, di religione, di opinioni politiche, di condizioni personali e sociali. È compito della Repubblica rimuovere gli ostacoli di ordine economico e sociale, che, limitando di fatto la libertà e l'eguaglianza dei cittadini, impediscono il pieno sviluppo della persona umana e l'effettiva partecipazione di tutti i lavoratori all'organizzazione politica, economica e sociale del Paese.

B **Compare your ideas with another pair.**

STEP 3 TAKING ACTION

Class debate

5A **Work in two groups, A and B. Prepare to debate the question below.**

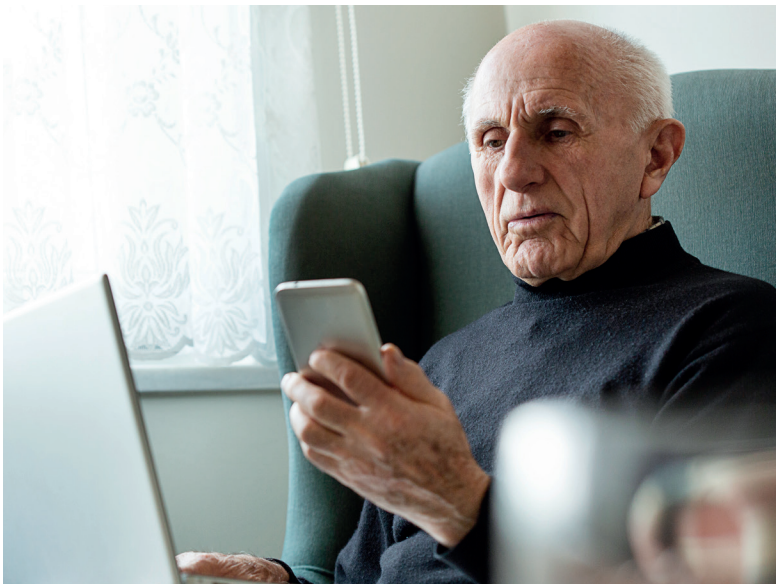
> "Should digital skills training be included in formal school curricula from primary level?"

Group A: Make a list of reasons why this is a good idea.

Group B: Make a list of reasons why this is not a good idea.

B **Prepare to present your ideas to the other group.**

C **Take turns to debate your ideas.**



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